STAR POWER

"With OTT, I have got the right kind of audience and the appreciation I was looking for as an actor"

–SANYA MALHOTRA



› THE WRITE WAY
Sanya Malhotra maintains a book in which she jots down her thoughts on the characters she is playing. For *Pagglait*, she wrote poems on silences and loneliness to get into the skin of her character, Sandhya

› SANYA'S ROLE MODEL
Tabu–the senior actor has been her inspiration for the range of roles she has essayed on screen



◂ SOORYAVANSHI
The biggest Hindi film of 2021 with collections of Rs 196 crore



BELLBOTTOM ▸
The Akshay-starrer was the first big-budget film to release in cinemas after the Covid second wave

North and West markets desperately needed. Kumar, though, isn't sticking to just theatrical releases; he has hopped on the streaming bandwagon too. On December 24, he had his second straight-to-digital release in Disney+ Hotstar's *Atrangi Re*.

Stars like Kumar are aware that OTT platforms will continue to make inroads. Some of the finest performers on OTT include Manoj Bajpayee who was in peak form again in season two of Prime Video's *The Family Man*. It took Konkona Sensharma all of 30 minutes to remind us what a skilled performer she is in the short *Geeli Puchhi*, part of the Netflix anthology *Ajeeb Daastaans*. She followed it up with another assured performance in the ensemble drama, *Mumbai Diaries 26/11,* on Prime Video.

It was Sanya Malhotra, though, who was the revelation of 2021 with two Netflix releases—*Pagglait* and *Meenakshi Sundareshwar*. Through these, she demonstrated that she is more than capable of spearheading a project. Since *Pagglait's* release in March, the actress has noticed a discernible shift in her professional life as more nuanced parts come her way along with popular filmmakers. Her upcoming line-up includes Meghna Gulzar's *Sam Bahadur* opposite Vicky Kaushal, *HIT The First Case* alongside Rajkummar Rao, a film produced by Shah Rukh Khan's Red Chillies and a project with Atlee. "With OTT I get to entertain audiences and there's less box office pressure," says Malhotra. "It's a nice feeling to not have to worry about numbers."

Malhotra hasn't had to worry about numbers since last year when she also had two direct-to-digital releases in *Shakuntala Devi* and *Ludo*. "I've got the right kind of audience and the appreciation I was looking for through OTT," she says. In a career spanning just about six years, the 29-year-old has taken a rather unconventional route thus far. It began with *Dangal* which taught her "to focus on what you can provide to the script with your performance than worry about the screen time". It's also about the different shades of women she chooses to essay, be it a lonely widow discovering an inconvenient truth about her husband (*Pagglait*) or a bride negotiating distance in an arranged-come-love marriage (*Meenakshi Sundareshwar*). "Unconsciously, your values do reflect in the characters you do," she says. "Not every character is relatable. But you need to convince yourself first, only then can you convince the audience."

Going by Netflix data, Malhotra has pulled it off. *Pagglait* was in the top 10 in India for a few weeks while *Meenakshi Sundareshwar* figured in the top 10 film titles for six weeks, with an appearance in the top 10 global films list for three consecutive weeks. On social media, her fans make Instagram reels imitating her steps to 'Ittar Bittar', a playful track from *Meenakshi...*, while critics and award shows acknowledged her work in *Pagglait*. As Malhotra looks ahead to 2022, she is conscious about not becoming complacent. "I am always thinking, how can I learn something new about acting and experiment with the work?" she says. "I am scared of repeating my characters. It is an unattainable goal, I know, but I perform better when I am putting pressure on myself." ■